

Citizens, Politicians and the Media: Evaluating Democratic Processes

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University of Gothenburg

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Table of contents

1.	General information	2
1.1.	Content of the course	2
1.2.	Logic of the course	2
1.3.	Academic integrity and use of artificial intelligence	3
1.4.	Literature	4
2.	The input-heavy side: Lectures and seminars	4
2.1.	Introduction and welcome	5
2.2.	Lecture 1. How and why do citizens engage in politics.....	5
2.3.	Lecture 2. Political representation in contemporary democracy.....	6
2.4.	Lecture 3. Election campaigns	7
2.5.	Lecture 4. Changing media environments: threats to democracy?.....	7
2.6.	Written exam	8
3.	The output-heavy side: Research review	9
3.1.	Purpose and organization.....	9
3.2.	The process of writing the review	10
4.	Course requirements and grading.....	11
5.	Compensatory tasks.....	12
5.1.	Compensatory tasks for missed seminar or workshop.....	12
6.	About equal treatment	13

1. General information

The schedule and all other information are available from the course web site (CANVAS SF2222). Any changes, additions, or other messages will be posted there. Please check your GU student email address and the Canvas web site regularly during the course.

1.1. Content of the course

A major goal of democracy is to realize “the will of the people.” But how should this be achieved? How is it achieved in reality? To find out, this course focuses on three groups of actors: citizens, politicians, and the media. We consider research on voting behaviour, political psychology, political participation, and political representation. Moreover, we examine theories and empirical research on political communication, journalism and media. What does this research tell us about these actors and how they interact under different circumstances? How do these actors, and the relations between them, fulfill requirements imposed by different models of democracy? What does research reveal about how various democratic values can be realized?

Specifically, the course has three aims:

1. To develop your knowledge of, and ability to critically evaluate theories and empirical research on voting behaviour, public opinion, political psychology, political participation, political representation, political communication, journalism and media.
2. To develop your ability to analyze democratic issues in light of empirical research. To what extent do *current* democratic processes live up to the ideals and assumptions of normative models of democracy? Which democratic reforms seem promising given that we want to realize certain democratic models and values?
3. To develop the participants’ academic writing and oral presentation skills.

1.2. Logic of the course

The theoretical and empirical content of the course is described in detail below where the learning activities are outlined. The pedagogical idea of the course can be summarized as structured into an “input-heavy” part and an “output-heavy” part.

Input-heavy part – *learning how others think*

The introduction is followed by a series of sub-themes covering different aspects of the relation between citizens, politicians and the media. Each theme is introduced with a lecture and also contains a seminar where theory and empirical research findings are discussed:

- THEME 1: Public opinion and participation (lecture 1+ seminar 1),
- THEME 2: Political representation (lecture 2 + seminar 2),
- THEME 3: Parties, candidates and election campaigns(l lecture 3 + seminar 3),
- THEME 4: Media environment (lecture 4 + seminar 4)

The aim of this part of the course is to provide a good overview of what research has shown so far. This knowledge is tested in a written exam about halfway through the course. The exam is based on the literature and the lectures covered to this point.

When studying, students are encouraged to systematically create their own summaries of each lecture and of the corresponding literature. Such summaries are sometimes called portfolios and become a concrete result of the course for the students to bring with them. They will also help students in the second part of the course as they provide a basis for the research review. Students are also encouraged to study together, discussing interpretations of the literature.

Output-heavy part – *writing and presenting yourself*

After the written exam, students start working on a research review aiming at deepening the understanding of a specific area. The topic of the research review is chosen based on the themes from the first part of the course. Students are encouraged to raise questions during lectures/seminars connected to areas of their specific interest. The task of the students is to write a research review by 1) formulating a broad research problem; 2) developing more specific research questions following from the general research problem, as well as 3) answering these research questions analytically based on existing research.

1.3. Academic integrity and use of artificial intelligence

We take academic integrity very seriously. To fulfill the course requirements, you therefore have to conduct a self-teaching module on Canvas called Introduction to Academic Honesty on academic integrity. It takes ca 20 minutes and you can try as many times as you like. But you have to pass it to fulfill the course requirements.

In this course, the use of generative AI to create content for examination items is completely prohibited. However, it is allowed to use AI tools to improve the language, e.g., in the research review. Students who do not follow this rule will be reported to the Disciplinary Board for using “unauthorized aids” (see GU's rules for disciplinary matters). Add a note in your research review that clarifies how and for what purposes you have used AI tools.

To further help you avoid any suspicions of plagiarism, we list below some of the basic—and hugely important—principles for independent academic writing. Any attempt of fraudulent behavior will be documented.

- Academic writing is based on the principle of clarity and transparency regarding the origin of the information and knowledge conveyed by the text.
- Academic texts are characterized by independent and self-designed writing.
- In combination, the above principles mean that in academic writing we use the ideas, thoughts, arguments, opinions, conclusions of others, but we make clear the origin of these by quoting and referring. We communicate with, build on, and credit previous research, authors, sources, *but* we do not copy them! Copying is plagiarism, which is the same as cheating.
- Some examples of plagiarism: 1) Copying an existing text; 2) moving and deleting a few words from an existing text; 3) translating an existing text from another language; 4) copying from a previous assignment you wrote (self-plagiarism). Please note that none of these examples qualify

as legitimate academic writing regardless of whether a reference is present or if the text is presented as one's own description and / or analysis.

- There should be no doubt whatsoever in the text about which ideas, thoughts, arguments, opinions and conclusions are yours (absent a reference) and which arguments you obtained from other texts (reference to the author included). There are different reference styles (see more about this at <http://www.ub.gu.se/skriva/referensstilar/>) but a good rule of thumb, for maximum transparency, is to include the reference in the text, like this: (author surname, year, page), i.e. (Sikkink, 2000, 13).
- When an author you read uses particular wording to describe something, and you wish to use this exact wording in your text, **this wording should be marked as a quote**, with a reference that includes a page reference, such as (author surname, year: page). As stated, always including page numbers in the references in the text – whether cited or not – is a good rule of thumb!
- To put it simply, you avoid plagiarism 1) by always writing independently (never ‘copy and paste’), 2) by quoting, and 3) by the careful and frequent use of references.
- The Department of Political Science uses the Urkund control system against plagiarism. Our teachers are also very good at detecting texts that are not self-authored through our own critical reading experience. We are obliged to report suspicion of cheating to the Disciplinary Board at GU. Cheating can result in a warning or even a suspension from education.
- If you use any artificial intelligence for writing your text, you have to add at the end of your review a declaration explaining exactly how you used it.

Additional information and knowledge on ‘Searching and citing,’ ‘Plagiarism,’ ‘Language support’ and the webcourse on ‘Academic Honesty is available at UoG:s Student Portal (student environment & rules > disciplinary matters).

1.4. Literature

We do not have a textbook for this course. All of the required literature comes in form of individual research articles and chapters, listed below for each lecture. These form the basis for the exam. But in order to do well on the course, it is advisable to read more broadly. We suggest two books for that:

- Dalton, Russell J. 2020, *Citizen Politics. Public Opinion and Political Parties in Advanced Industrial Democracies*. Seventh edition. Washington DC: CQ Press.
- Iyengar, Shanto. 2023, *Media Politics*. Fifth edition. A Citizen’s Guide. New York: WW Norton & Co. (The fourth edition is also ok).

2. The input-heavy side: Lectures and seminars

Below you find outlines of the four themes of the course, including an abstract of the topics covered and the relevant course literature. It is advisable, but not necessary, that you read the texts before the introductory lectures. Please that some readings are marked as “optional”; they are relevant for the topic but are not included in the texts for the examinations. For each theme

there is a seminar task which you find in Canvas (under Modules). Lecture presentations will also be posted under Modules.

2.1. Introduction and welcome

Nicklas Håkansson

Abstract: During this first meeting we introduce the course and its learning activities and examinations. We also aim to get to know each other a bit more.

THEME 1: Public opinion and participation (Ann-Kristin Kölln)

2.2. Lecture 1. How and why do citizens engage in politics

Abstract: This theme examines how and why citizens engage in politics by linking theories of political opinion, participation, and voting behaviour. It starts from the insight that political opinions are not fixed but constructed, shaped by information, predispositions, heuristics, and framing. Citizens rely on cognitive shortcuts, such as party cues, social group identities, and media frames, to navigate complex political environments. The theme then turns to political participation, conceptualised broadly to include both conventional and unconventional forms of engagement, and explained through the Civic Voluntarism Model, which highlights the roles of resources, psychological orientations, and mobilization. Finally, the theme explores voting behaviour through sociological, socio-psychological, and rational choice models, emphasising social cleavages, party identification, and evaluations of performance. Throughout, the course critically assesses issues of causality and applies theories to real-world cases, encouraging students to evaluate how citizens think, act, and vote in contemporary democracies.

Literature

Bartels, Larry M. (2010). The Study of Electoral Behavior. In Leighley, Jan E., (Ed.). *The Oxford Handbook of American Elections and Political Behavior*. Oxford, Oxford University Press. (e-book)

Chong, Dennis, & Druckman, James N. (2007). Framing Theory. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 10(1), 103-126.

Evans, Geoffrey (2000). The continued significance of class voting. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 3(1), 401-417.

Lau, Richard R., & Redlawsk, David P. (2001). Advantages and disadvantages of cognitive heuristics in political decision making. *American Journal of Political Science*, 45(4), 951-971.

Schlozmann, Kay L., & Brady, Henry E. (2022). Political Science and Political Participation, In Marco Giugni & Maria Grasso (Eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Political Participation* (pp. 25-44). Oxford, Oxford University Press. (e-book)

Stubager R. How Are Social Groups Linked to the Vote? Social Group Perceptions and Party Choice. *British Journal of Political Science*. 2025;55:e146. doi:10.1017/S0007123425000444

Willeck, Claire & Mendelberg, Tali (2022). Education and Political Participation. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 25, 89-110. [only pages 89-94]

Seminar Theme 1: See Canvas/Modules!

THEME 2: Political representation (Jacob Gunderson)

2.3. Lecture 2. Political representation in contemporary democracy

Lecture: Representation and Responsiveness in Theory

The idea of *representation* is key to modern democracy, but what kind of relationship does it entail between the people and those who rule on its behalf? This lecture focuses on the conceptual definition of representation in its various forms and its delineation from related, but critical concepts, like *responsiveness*. It also describes how selective misinformation and misperceptions can degrade the quality of representation.

Literature:

Barnes, Tiffany D. and Mirya R. Holman (2020). "Gender Quotas, Women's Representation, and Legislative Diversity." *Journal of Politics* 82(4): 1271 - 1286

Carnes, Nicholas and Noam Lupu (2023). "The Economic Backgrounds of Politicians". *Annual Review of Political Science* 26: 253-270.

Folke Olle, Johanna Rickne (2025). "The Class Ceiling in Politics". *American Political Science Review* 119(3): 1375 – 1392.

Giger, Natalie and Klüver, Heike. (2016), Voting Against Your Constituents? How Lobbying Affects Representation. *American Journal of Political Science*, 60: 190-205. doi:10.1111/ajps.12183.

Ibenskas, Raimondas and Jonathan Polk. (2022). "Congruence and party responsiveness in Western Europe in the 21st century." *West European Politics* 45(2): 201-222

Magni, Gabriele and Andrew Reynolds (2021). "Voter Preferences and the Political Underrepresentation of Minority Groups: Lesbian, Gay, and Transgender Candidates in Advanced Democracies" *Journal of Politics* 83(4): 1199-1215.

Mansbridge, Jane. (2003). "Rethinking Representation" *American Political Science Review* 97(4): 515-528.

Pitkin, Hanna Fenichel. (1972). *The Concept of Representation*. University of California Press: Berkeley. (Selections),

Reynolds, Andrew (2013). "Representation and Rights: The Impact of LGBT Legislators in Comparative Perspective." *American Political Science Review* 107(2): 259–74. doi: 10.1017/S0003055413000051.

Wängnerud, Lena (2009). Women in Parliaments: Descriptive and Substantive Representation. *Annual Review of Political Science* 12:51-59

Walgrave, Stefaan et al. (2022). "Inaccurate Politicians: Elected Representatives' Estimations of Public Opinion in Four Countries." *The Journal of Politics*. 85(1): 209-222.

Seminar Theme 2: See Canvas/Modules!

THEME 3: Parties, candidates and election campaigns (Nicklas Håkansson)

2.4. Lecture 3. Election campaigns

Abstract: This theme focuses on the election campaigns mostly from the point of view of the political parties. It covers the history of election campaigns and discusses concepts like 'professionalization' and 'marketization'. The literature covers trends and characteristics of campaigning in today's hybrid media landscape, including campaign efforts in social media. Another central research topic is negative campaigning which is a common feature in political campaigns, especially in the US. How widespread is the strategy to go negative, how can it be explained and what are the effects – on voters and democracy?

Literature

Boulianne, Shelley & Larsson, Anders Olof (2023) Engagement with candidate posts on Twitter, Instagram, and Facebook during the 2019 election. *New Media & Society* 25:1, 119-140.

Lau, Richard R., Sigelman, Lee, & Rovner, Ivy Brown (2007). The effects of negative political campaigns: a metaanalytic reassessment. *Journal of Politics*, 69(4), 1176-1209.

Lees-Marshment, Jennifer (2001). The marriage of politics and marketing. *Political Studies*. Vol 49: 692-713.

Mykkänen, Juri, Nord, Lars & Moring, Tom (2021) Ten years after: Is the party-centered theory of campaign professionalization still valid? *Party Politics* 1-11.

Valli, Chiara & Nai, Alessandro (2020) Attack politics from Albania to Zimbabwe: A large-scale comparative study on the drivers of negative campaigning. *International Political Science Review* 1-17.

Walter, Annemarie. S. (2014). Negative campaigning in Western Europe: Similar or different?. *Political Studies*, 62(1_suppl), 42-60.

Optional reading:

Iyengar *Media Politics*. Chapter 5+6.

Seminar Theme 3: See Canvas/Modules!

THEME 4: Media environment (Isabella Glogger)

2.5. Lecture 4. Changing media environments: threats to democracy?

Abstract: A well-functioning society relies on citizens staying informed about current societal and political events. Recent changes in the news media and political information environment

pose a threat to this necessity. In the lecture and seminar, we focus on concerns that are associated with obstacles for knowledge acquisition in such changing environments, such as citizens increasingly avoiding the news and encountering misinformation/disinformation. We discuss, furthermore, fact-checking initiatives and media literacy interventions as potential remedies for these problematic developments.

Literature:

Threats:

Broda, E., & Strömbäck, J. (2024). Misinformation, disinformation, and fake news: lessons from an interdisciplinary, systematic literature review. *Annals of the International Communication Association*, 48(2), 139-166.

Castro, L., Strömbäck, J., Esser, F., Van Aelst, P., De Vreese, C., Aalberg, T., Cardenal, A. S., Corbu, N., Hopmann, D. N., Koc-Michalska, K., Matthes, J., Schemer, C., Sheafer, T., Splendore, S., Stanyer, J., Stępińska, A., Štětka, V., & Theocharis, Y. (2022). Navigating High-Choice European Political Information Environments: A Comparative Analysis of News User Profiles and Political Knowledge. *The International Journal of Press/Politics*, 27(4), 827–859. <https://doi.org/10.1177/19401612211012572>

Damstra, A., Vliegenthart, R., Boomgaarden, H., Glüer, K., Lindgren, E., Strömbäck, J., & Tsfati, Y. (2023). Knowledge and the News: An Investigation of the Relation Between News Use, News Avoidance, and the Presence of (Mis)beliefs. *The International Journal of Press/Politics*, 28(1), 29–48. <https://doi.org/10.1177/19401612211031457>

Skovsgaard, M., & Andersen, K. (2020). Conceptualizing News Avoidance: Towards a Shared Understanding of Different Causes and Potential Solutions. *Journalism Studies*, 21(4), 459–476. <https://doi.org/10.1080/1461670X.2019.1686410>

Remedies:

Droog, E., Vermeulen, I., van Huijstee, D., Harutyunyan, D., Tejedor, S., & Pulido, C. (2024). Combatting the misinformation crisis: A systematic review of the literature on characteristics and effectiveness of media literacy interventions. *Communication Research*.

Hameleers, M. (2022). Separating truth from lies: Comparing the effects of news media literacy interventions and fact-checkers in response to political misinformation in the US and Netherlands. *Information, communication & society*, 25(1), 110-126.

Walter, N., Cohen, J., Holbert, R. L., & Morag, Y. (2020). Fact-checking: A meta-analysis of what works and for whom. *Political Communication*, 37(3), 350-375.

Seminar Theme 4: See Canvas/Modules!

2.6. Written exam

The written exam covers only the literature for the first part of the course. It is a closed-book, sit-down exam with typically four questions. Example can be found on CANVAS.

Please note that you need to **sign up for the exam** well in advance, no later than 10 days before it takes place. If you don't sign up **you will be denied to write the exam**. For more information:

Make sure to bring a **valid** identity document to the exam. Ask the course administrator if you are unsure whether your ID is valid. Note that your student card is not a valid identity document.

If you are late, you will be denied to write the exam. Make sure you know when you have to be there (you need to be there in advance).

Note that the exam is an electronic exam and that you need a computer with correct programs. Make sure you have read all instructions and have done all trials online well in advance. And again, make sure you follow their guidelines on how long you need to be there in advance. If you cannot bring your own computer, you must book one well ahead. Here you find information about the electronic exam:

<https://studentportal.gu.se/english/e-services/written-examination/in-the-exam-hall/?languageId=100001&skipSSOCheck=true>

Please also note that it is not allowed to consume certain types of foods (e.g. nuts) during the exam.

If you are eligible to obtain special assistance for sitting the exam, please let the course admin (see email address on first page) know at least 4 weeks before the exam.

Students are encouraged to arrange a pre-exam seminar that they themselves design. A room is booked for this purpose.

3. The output-heavy side: Research review

3.1. Purpose and organization

Your task in the research review is to 1) formulate a broad research problem; 2) develop more specific research questions following from the general research problem, as well as 3) answer these research questions analytically based on existing research. Also, the review is the most important basis for your grade and the presentations provide you with a range of perspectives from your fellow student colleagues in several areas.

Students start working on their review after the written exam. A lecture introducing the review writing takes place after the exam.

We anticipate that the average report will be 4,000 words. Reports that are longer than 5,000 words will not be accepted.

A good report should do the following:

- Identify, develop, and propose an important research problem and specify research questions that follow well from the problem.

- Give reasonable, knowledge-based, answers to the questions you specify. Discuss the most important theoretical arguments found in the research literature, as well as the most relevant empirical results. Base your answer both on the course literature as well as additional references from the field. If relevant, include empirical illustrations from your own analyses. An important part of your essay is to discuss the strengths and weaknesses of the research you have taken into account: Are the theoretical ideas and empirical methods reasonable and sound? Do you accept the conclusions? Why/Why not? What types of studies are missing in order for research to answer the question properly?
- Provide a compelling argument regarding the democratic relevance of this research. In order to do this, you need to confront different normative models of democracy, grounded in democratic theory. To what extent do current democratic processes meet the standards of various normative models of democracy? What does this research suggest about how democratic processes could be improved, given that we want to realize certain democratic ideals and values?

You are free to organize your review anyway you like. Try to find the structure that works best for “the story” you want to tell. It is an analytical task for you to identify a nucleus of important ideas and research results, which will make for a coherent and readable review.

We expect you to follow standard rules for referencing and that you show that you have taken into account both course literature and additional literature suggested to you during supervision. Please note that it is good if you succeed in connecting your topic to parts of the course literature in this way, but we are not impressed by superficial “name dropping” doing little to improve the discussion. Don’t forget to include a list of references at the end of your review, so that others can comfortably read and use it in the future. Also, give your review a substantive title (rather than calling it “review”). Have a look at the rules for academic writing, including the use of AI tools. It summarizes what we expect from you.

3.2. The process of writing the review

Students are assisted during this phased of the course through a supervisor as well as peer-to-peer-element. It is mandatory to provide early, work-in-progress, versions of the review at the following four occasions (please find the dates/deadlines in the timetable):

1. Writing workshop 1: Oral presentation and feedback of ideas among peers. Students present their idea and get/give oral feedback from/to other students in their group. A lecturer will be around at least some of the time to answer small questions. The group jointly fill in and upload a protocol on CANVAS by the end of the session. Instructions and template for protocol is provided on CANVAS.
2. Supervision/feedback 1: You upload a *one-page introduction* where you formulate a specification of the research problem that will be investigated, as well as suggest specific research questions. You should also include a preliminary reference list outlining literature you intend to use. The course coordinator will match you with a supervisor, who comments your text briefly, as well as suggests more literature for you to consider. Teacher response will be given in writing within a day.
3. Writing workshop 2: Students bring two printed copies of their paper to other group members. All read two papers (divide as you see fit) and help by making notes in the text. Afterwards students discuss each paper for about 15 minutes, where the readers of the paper kick off the discussion. Focus is on constructive ways forward in theoretical and empirical arguments, not on format. A lecturer will be around at least some of the time to

answer small questions. The groups fill in a joint protocol again. Instructions and template for protocol is provided on CANVAS.

4. Review seminar/feedback 2: You submit a *five-page* text (ca.) in which you have re-written the specification of the research problem as well as the specific research questions – and where you provide a first draft of answers to the questions based on the literature you are studying. This text is discussed at a seminar where each student comments another student's paper. You are expected to contribute to the discussion in connection to the other presentations. A teacher will moderate the seminar and also give feedback on the papers.

After the second writing workshop, you have time to finalize your paper. It must be uploaded onto CANVAS at the specified deadline (see timetable).

4. Course requirements and grading

Here are the dimensions along which we evaluate your efforts:

	<u>Weak</u>	<u>Satisfactory</u>	<u>Excellent</u>
<u>1. COHERENCE:</u> Is there a clear story and argument throughout the review?			
<u>2. USE OF LITERATURE:</u> Does the review engage with relevant theories and empirical research found in the literature?			
<u>3. ORIGINALITY AND INDEPENDENCE:</u> Does the review develop perspectives and arguments that are based on but also go beyond the research literature?			
<u>4. DEMOCRATIC RELEVANCE:</u> How persuasively does the review engage with issues concerning the democratic implications of empirical research?			

The following requirements apply for passing the course:

- Passing the online modules on academic integrity (1 and 2)
- Passing the written exam.
- A satisfactory review.
- Sending in two preliminary reviews (“1-page” + “5-page”) to teachers and participating in the review seminar.
- Participating in two writing workshops. In the first one you bring your idea and present it orally, in the second one you bring two paper copies for others to read and you comment yourself on two papers.
- Active participation in final seminar discussions.

The written exam, the review, and the review seminar performance all affect the final grade. The two most important elements are the review and the exam. The exam is graded as pass (G), pass with distinction (VG) or not pass (U). The final version of the research review will only be graded

(as U, G or VG). Participation in the workshops and the review seminar is graded as U or G. Failure to participate in the above four steps will mean that additional tasks will be assigned for each missed step.

In order to pass the course (grade G), the student needs at least G in the written exam and the essay as well as show active participation in the review seminar. To pass the course with distinction (grade VG) the student needs VG on either the written exam *or* the review essay *as well as* active participation in the review seminar.

5. Compensatory tasks

Each compensatory task will consist of writing a one-page home essay. The specific tasks are found below. They should be handed in at the specified deadline (see schedule), and will then be evaluated together with the other exams/reports within the three weeks-limit that the teachers have to finalize grades.

5.1. Compensatory tasks for missed seminar or workshop

Additional task for students missing one or both of the writing workshops, handing in the first “1-page”) idea for the review, and/or the “5-page” draft and the review seminar.

Your task is to **write a one-page (max. 500 words) home exam on one of the following subjects**. If you missed more than one of the four occasions you write 2, 3 respectively 4 exam questions and hand in a page-long answer of each.

The tasks will be graded by the next grading occasion after the end of the course. Grades are G/U and the texts will be commented by the teacher only if grading is borderline.

1. The Civic Voluntarism Model is an important explanation for political participation. Choose two peer-reviewed articles that are not on your reading list for the class and that use the model empirically and summarize how they operationalize the most important concepts of the model.
2. Political representation of young people is not easily achieved. Choose two peer-reviewed research articles that are not on your reading list for the class studying youth representation and describe their main take-aways.
3. Election campaigning is assumed to have become professionalized over the years. Choose two articles that are not on your reading list for the class dealing with campaign professionalization and describe what they mean by professionalization.
4. Mediatization is often regarded as a general tendency of societal change. Often the concept is dealt with in theory. Here you should briefly outline two examples of empirical evidence of mediatization discussed in the literature. Choose articles that are not on the reading list of this course.

6. About equal treatment

The University of Gothenburg aims to promote equal rights and opportunities for students and employees and to combat discrimination related to gender, gender identity or gender expressions, ethnicity, religion or other beliefs, sexual orientation, disability or age. If, however, you as a student at the Department of Political Science become subject to such acts and actions, we encourage you to contact us to enable the opportunity for appropriate action. You can contact: the course coordinator, director of studies Lena Wängnerud, equal treatment representative Lisbeth Aggestam, or student counselor Sara Birgersson. Student counselors have confidentiality. You can also turn to these people if you experience problems or discomfort in the study environment, even if this is not directly aimed at you. All necessary contact information is available on our website.